'I've decided to retire from all forms of international cricket at the end of this Test.'

The room fell completely silent. Nobody moved.

Graeme continued: 'This has been the most difficult decision of my life, but it's something I have been thinking about since my ankle surgery last year. I have a young family to consider and it seems to me that retiring at Newlands is the best way to end it because I have called this place home since I was 18 years old.'

Of course, after more than a decade as captain, after so many colossal performances, Graeme had many times over earned the right to step aside precisely when he wanted, but I was concerned about the impact on the team. As Oscar Wilde might have put it, to lose one legendary player could be considered unfortunate but to lose two legendary players within the space of barely eight weeks seemed careless. Replacing Jacques was going to be difficult. Replacing Graeme would also be difficult. Replacing both at the same time would be impossible.

In an ideal world, we would have returned to Newlands on the fourth day, dismissed Australia for very few and chased down the target, giving our captain one last victory to enjoy. Unfortunately, the tourists raced to 303, effectively batting us out of the game and setting us an utterly impossible target of 511 to win.

Graeme opened our second innings with Alviro, and was given a guard of honour by the Australians as he walked out to bat for South Africa for the very last time. One last defiant century would have been appropriate but, instead, he scored only three runs before fending Johnson and being caught at short leg. He walked slowly back to the pavilion as the applause of opponents, teammates and spectators alike reverberated around the ground.

We would have liked to have saved the match at least, and we fought hard. Hashim batted for two and a half hours while making 41, and I stuck around for five and a half hours, scoring 43 from 228 balls before